

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Reuters

Sir Keir Starmer met Wes Streeting, one of his possible leadership challengers, on Wednesday. Britain's [embattled](#) prime minister is clinging to power, despite four ministers resigning from his government—most of them allies of Mr Streeting, the health secretary. Rivals will need to secure the support of 81 Labour [MPs](#) to launch a challenge. Nervous bond markets pushed [Britain's borrowing costs](#) to their highest in years.

Donald Trump said that America “did not need any help with **Iran**” from Xi Jinping, as he set off for [talks with China's leader](#) in Beijing. Still, the pair are bound to touch on the conflict; Pete Hegseth, America's war secretary, is travelling with Mr Trump. Earlier Mr Hegseth insisted that a ceasefire with Iran remained intact. Oil prices steadied at around \$107 a barrel.

Trade, however, will probably be the main talking point in Beijing. At the last minute Jensen Huang—the boss of Nvidia, the world's most valuable company—joined a group of American chief executives flying to China with Mr Trump. America's president has said that he will also talk to Mr Xi about arms sales to [Taiwan](#). That breaks with precedent and has alarmed America's Asian allies.

America's Senate confirmed **Kevin Warsh** to the Federal Reserve's board of governors, clearing the way for a vote on his [nomination for chair](#) this week. He will face the difficult task of containing inflation while resisting Mr Trump's demands for lower interest rates. **Consumer prices** rose by 3.8% year over year in April—the fastest pace in three years—as the war drove up energy costs.

Samsung Electronics failed to agree a pay deal with its biggest union, raising the risk of a strike that would disrupt production at the [South Korean](#) tech giant—and hurt the country's wider economy. Workers want the firm to remove caps on bonuses as it profits from voracious demand for artificial-intelligence memory chips. The union has threatened an 18-day walkout beginning on May 21st.

A federal appeals court paused, for now, a ruling by the United States Court of International Trade against Mr Trump's 10% **tariff** on all imports to America. The president imposed the levy in February, citing a law from 1974, after the Supreme Court [blocked the bulk of his earlier tariffs](#). Last week the trade court ruled that Mr Trump misused the statute; his administration appealed.

Sam Altman took the stand to reject allegations that he broke a vow to keep OpenAI a non-profit organisation. A [lawsuit](#) brought by **Elon Musk**, who founded the AI lab alongside Mr Altman over a decade ago, accuses him of trying to “steal a charity” by turning it into a commercial venture. Mr Altman said OpenAI's for-profit arm was a “creative way” to keep the lab going.

700,000, the number of robotaxis expected to roam Chinese cities within five years, according to Goldman Sachs, a bank. [Read why](#) China wants more robots, but not fewer workers.



Photograph: Reuters

The America-Iran stalemate

Donald Trump will arrive in Beijing on Wednesday with his war against Iran [stuck in a stalemate](#). Iran's latest proposal for a permanent ceasefire, delivered on Sunday, was promptly dismissed by the Americans: the president described it as "TOTALLY UNACCEPTABLE" on social media. The warring parties have been unable to agree on issues including the duration of a moratorium on Iran's uranium enrichment and what to do with the highly enriched uranium the country already holds.

Mr Trump insists time will work in his favour: "We have a blockade...we don't have to rush anything," he said on Tuesday. The problem is that Iranian officials take the same view. According to recently released data, soaring petrol prices helped push American annual inflation to 3.8% in April, its highest in nearly three years. Each side believes economic pain will force the other to make big concessions. At the same time, neither seems eager to resume fighting. A long deadlock looms.



Photograph: Reuters

Sir Keir Starmer clings on, for now

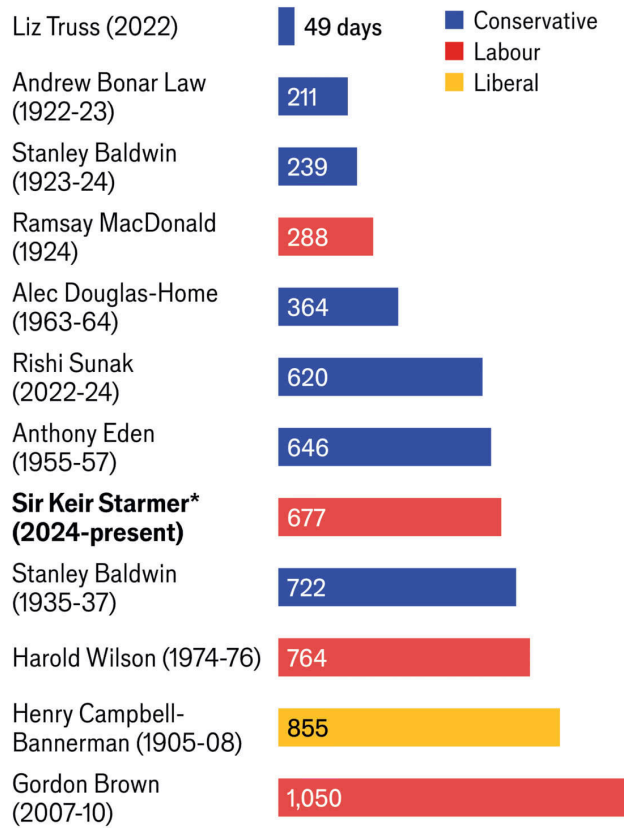
On Wednesday King Charles III is set to outline the British government's legislative plans in an address to Parliament. He won't mention the elephant in the chamber: the head of that government may soon have to quit, throwing the agenda into disarray.

Nearly 100 Labour Party MPs have called on Sir Keir Starmer to resign as prime minister. Some cabinet ministers, including Shabana Mahmood, the home secretary, have privately urged Sir Keir to go; some junior ministers have quit. Still, on Tuesday he averred that no one had launched a leadership challenge and said he would stay in office.

Few expect [Sir Keir to last much longer](#). But his pledge to plough on makes the process of replacing him messier. If a leadership challenge is triggered and Sir Keir chooses to stand, he will automatically be nominated. Meanwhile, each contender to replace him has flaws. Britain's governing party faces civil war.

Hit the ground

Britain, shortest-serving prime ministers
since 1900, days in office



*Still prime minister at May 12th 2026

Source: HM Government



Photograph: Getty Images

Japan's prodigal Son

Japanese firms may have a reputation for being risk-averse. Masayoshi Son, the founder of SoftBank Group, one of Japan's largest companies, is anything but. By October his [sprawling investment house](#) will have ploughed \$65bn into OpenAI, the artificial-intelligence firm behind ChatGPT. It will also soon pay \$5bn for the robotics arm of ABB, a Swiss engineering firm, and will snap up DigitalBridge, a data-centre business, for \$4bn.

SoftBank's earnings for the financial year ending in March—which it reported on Wednesday—suggest that its AI bets are paying off. Net profit quadrupled to ¥5trn (\$32bn); net sales were up nearly 8% to ¥7.8trn (\$49bn). Investors are enthusiastic. SoftBank's share price has surged lately, helping to lift Japan's benchmark Nikkei 225 index to a record high this week. But the firm's creditors are growing wary of the mounting debt needed to finance Mr Son's spending spree. In March s&p Global lowered its outlook for the group from stable to negative. With so much borrowed cash being funnelled into AI projects, SoftBank cannot afford to stumble.



Photograph: Getty Images

The red carpet and The White Lotus

For the next 11 days, the streets of Cannes will be teeming with Hollywood A-listers and the greats of international cinema. But fewer American movie stars may attend this year's film festival than normal.

Just two American films—"Paper Tiger", a gangster thriller, and "The Man I Love", a musical—are competing for the top prize, the Palm d'Or. Thierry Frémaux, the festival's director, has played down suggestions that American studios are retreating, but said that the decline in the number of blockbusters had made him "nostalgic" for the "golden age" of American cinema. He said problems in the industry, including strikes and the Los Angeles wildfires, had made it harder for Hollywood to "greenlight big films".

Ironically, another part of America's entertainment industry will be highly visible. Scenes from the upcoming series of the television hit ["The White Lotus"](#) are being filmed in Cannes during the festival. At a big-screen event, a small-screen production is generating much of the buzz.



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: The departure of which baseball player in 1920 is supposed to have resulted in a long-lasting curse on the Boston Red Sox?

Tuesday: Which American president was born in a town called Hope?

*Art is made to disturb. Science
reassures.*

Georges Braque